

losses. Those grievous events are more troublesome to Chartists, who must admit either that their charts were wrong or else that they misinterpreted the wiggles, both of which sound like mistakes. On the other hand, a Fundamentalist broker can simply say, "Your stock went down because its fundamental value is not yet recognized by the marketplace."

Though I never asked Ms. Garrett to declare herself, I called her several times to report on the conference and to get information. For instance, after meeting with Mr. Prechter, I asked her to send me the chart on Angstrom. She said she didn't have a chart, but would try to get one. After leaving Mr. Frank's room, I phoned her again, to inquire about Angstrom's current price/earnings ratio. She said she didn't know it offhand, but would try to find out. Between "very high" and "very low," she guessed it would have to be "very high."

A high P/E ratio would make Angstrom an emerging growth stock, as opposed to one of Mr. Frank's undervalued stocks. Although I'd been swayed momentarily by Mr. Frank, I left Fort Lauderdale convinced that the high P/E, emerging-growth scenario was the scenario that really made sense.

I'd hoped to make a second successful investment by now, but having seen all the trouble the experts go through, with nothing but widespread disagreement at the end of it, I was feeling a bit unsure of myself. Also, Angstrom had begun to slide almost immediately after I'd learned at the conference why I'd picked it. This is one more sorry example of how a little knowledge can be a dangerous thing.

In early February, the stock price fell from a high of $2\frac{3}{4}$ to $2\frac{3}{8}$ in a single day, losing 10 percent of its value. Maybe a lot of other people had just been taught what to look for in a growth company and decided all at once that Angstrom wasn't it.

I shared my concern with my broker, Ms. Garrett, who volunteered to check her source in Philadelphia, the man who recommended Angstrom in the first place and who'd been following it all along. I still didn't know his name, only that Ms. Garrett said he was very clever. She called back to report what he'd said: that the drop was due to "general market conditions" and "the smart